

Rollei Superpan 200 pro - first impression

Are we not already served with a good choice of mid range speed films? Do we really need another one? Does this film have any advantages over the already existing top end films in the range of 100 ASA? Does it reach its nominal speed? What does the sharpness look like? How about grain and resolution?

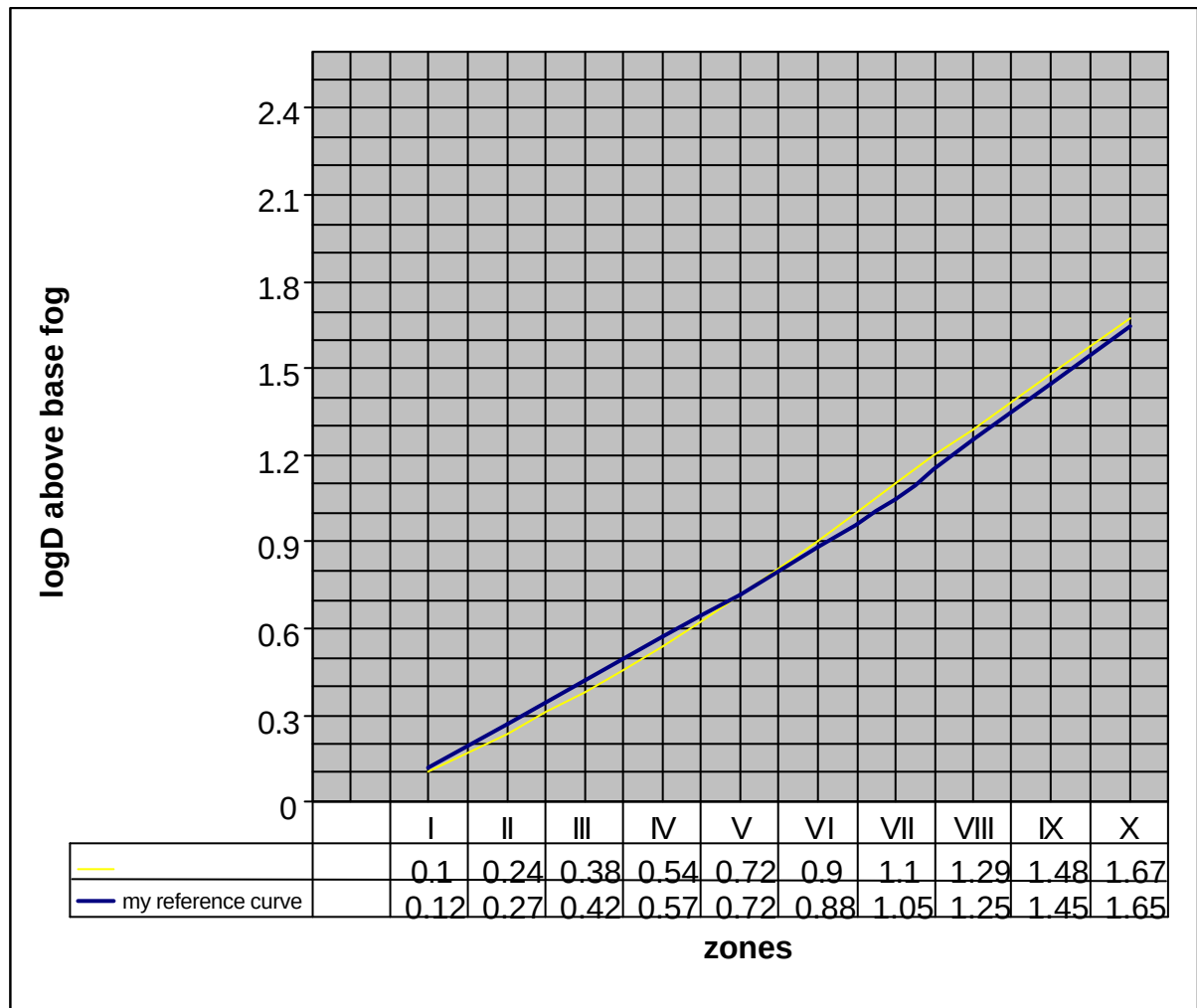
The expectations are high, not the least because of the specifications by the manufacturer. Is this all just marketing or can we trust this information? So far, I have no field report of any other user.

First we have to collect data with different developers in order to judge sharpness, grain and tonal values.

The first candidate was my preferred developer – Finol. The result met my expectations in terms of sharpness and grain. The speed of 160-250 ASA came as a surprise. When choosing a developer we often tend to be guided by credos or our readiness for compromise on a variety of film criteria. In photochemistry there is no such thing as an all in one solution for every purpose, but a combination of Superpan and Finol comes a step close to it. Tanol accomplishes comparable results at 100-160 ASA. Tanol Speed reaches the highest sensitivity.

The norm and the normative force of the fact

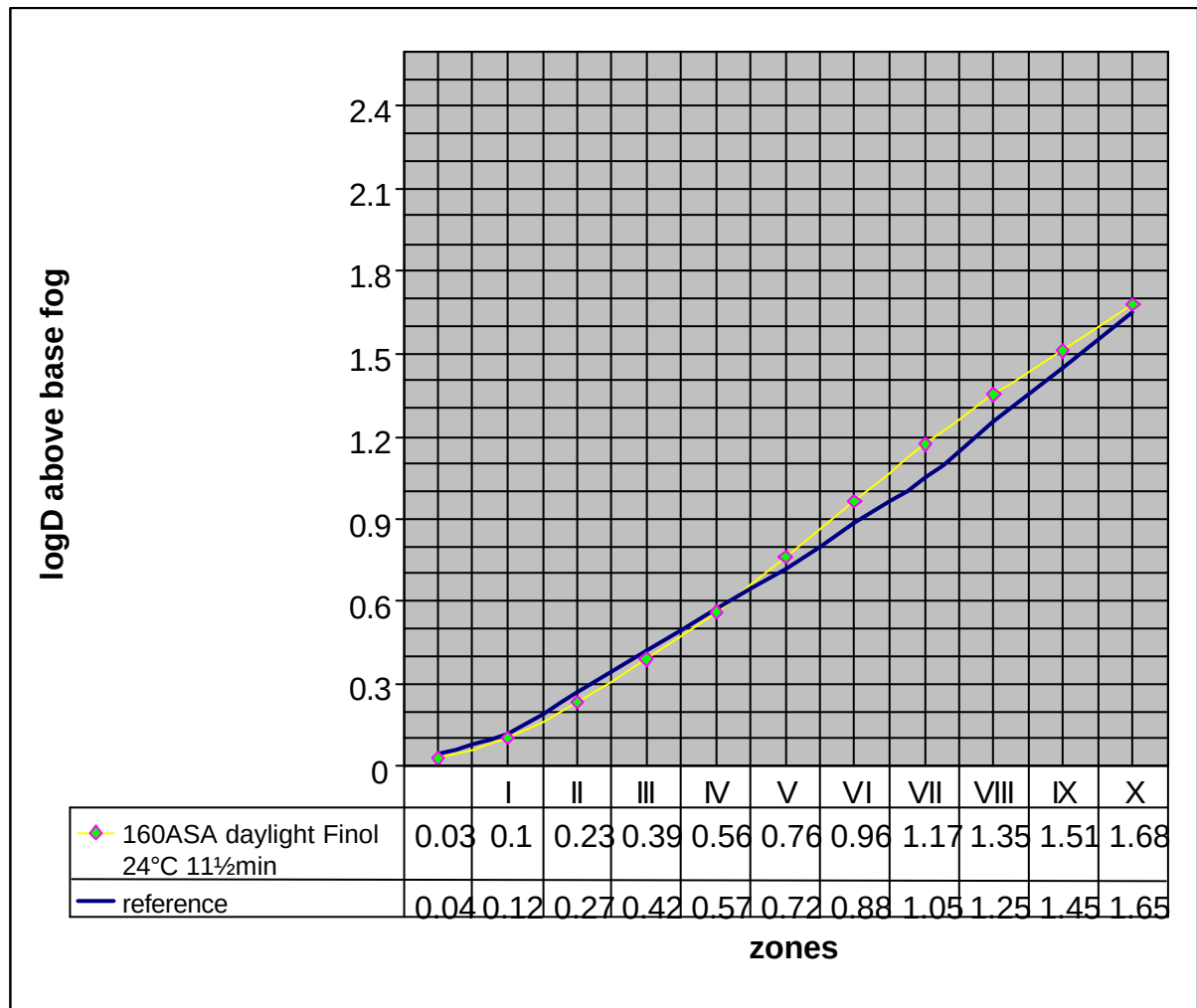
We have norms to be able to make comparable readings. If this leads to unsatisfactory results in practice, you should defy the norm. Clearly, I am not alone with this perception. If you have a look at the readings of those who published on the topics of calibration and the zone system, you will see that their values at the foot of the curve are a little bit higher than the ISO norm. The point for determining the real film speed is in zone I. Whether this zone has a value of 0.09 logD or 0.13 logD, is in itself not that important, because in the print this zone will be pitch black. We want to see delineation as of zone III. If the value for zone I is at 0.1 or below, in most cases the values for zones II and III will also be (too) low and a given value will not be reached until we get to zone IV. The more the foot of the curve is sagging, the harder it gets to put the desired tone value to paper. Especially if you have to over-develop the film to reach the norm film speed, which results in higher densities of the highlights (undesired, but inevitable).



The yellow line is another norm curve for comparison. To me, a straight lined ascent from the shadows to the midtones is more important than meeting any norms.

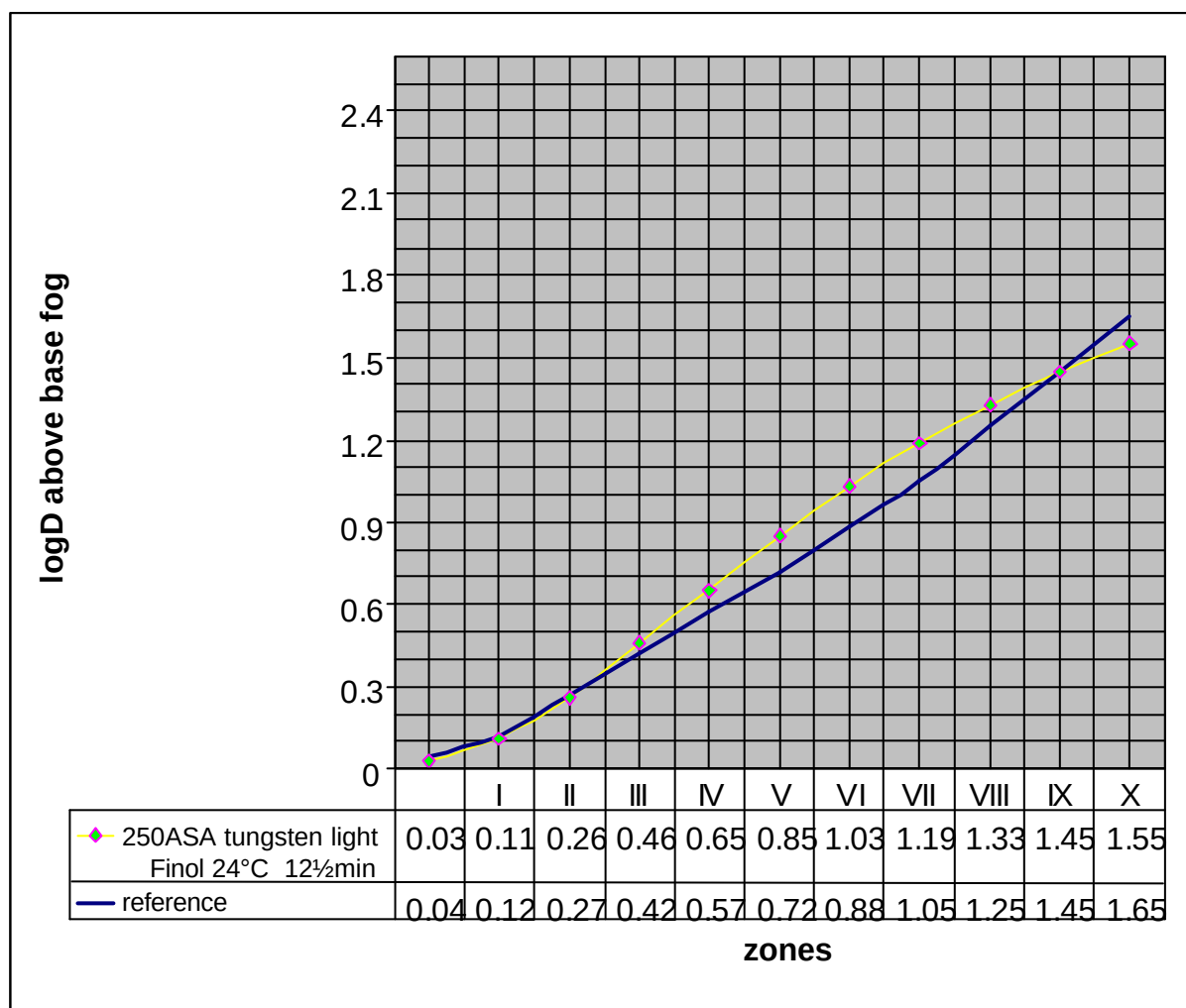
The determination point for the film speed is slightly higher, which also results in much higher values for the next zones. Compared to my reading, an ISO norm evaluation would result in an increase of film speed by 1°DIN.

Next, I want to show you a couple of curves with different developers.

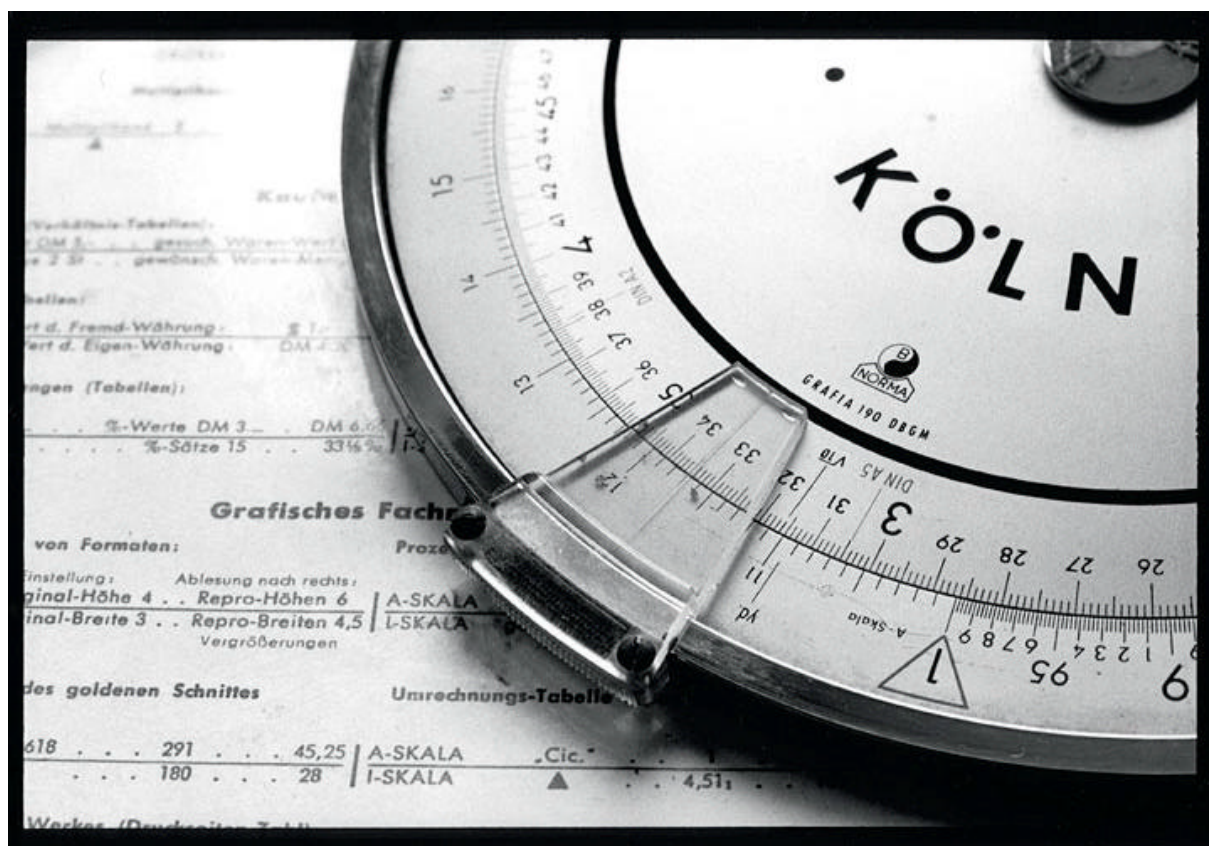


Using Finol the test in daylight results in a film speed of 160 ASA

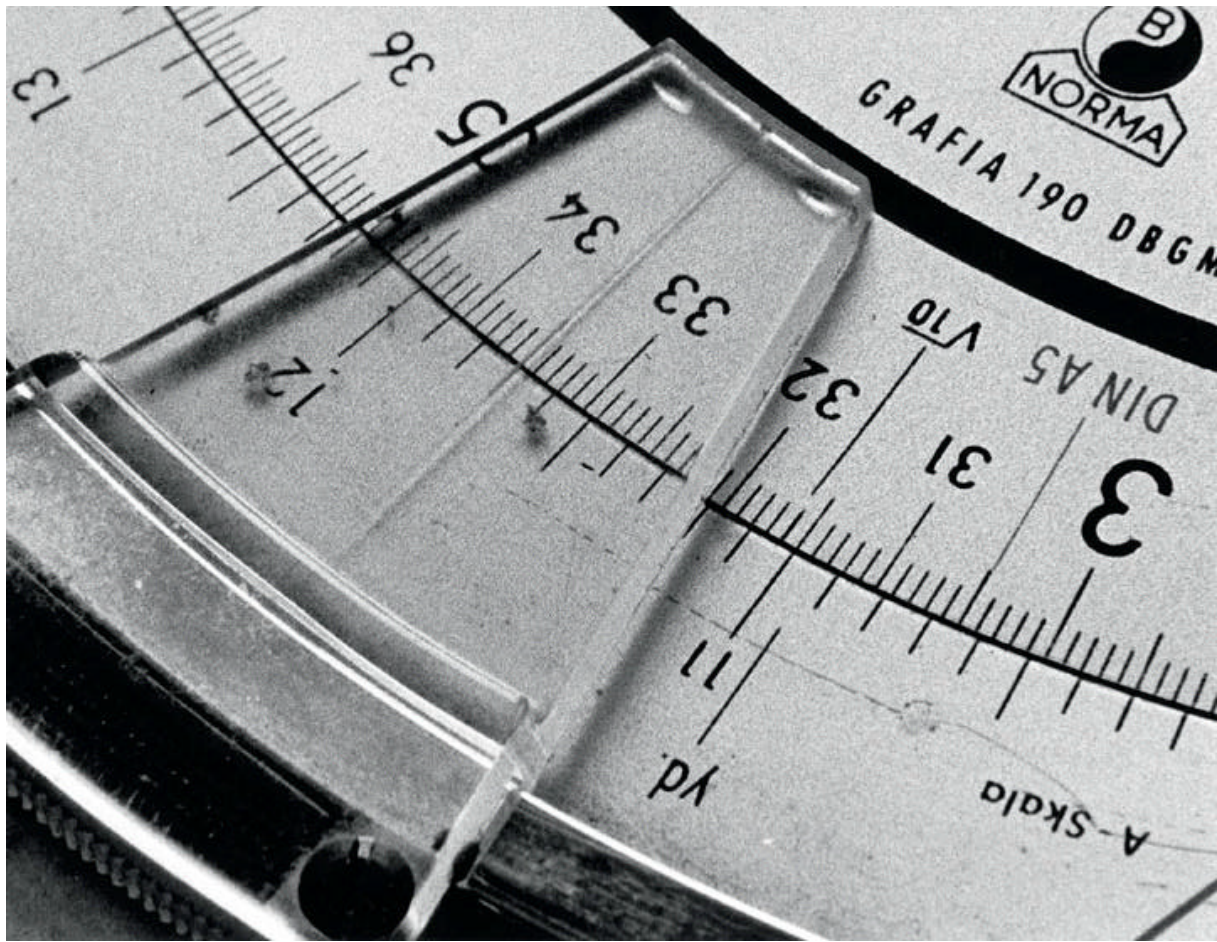
As with all other developers as well, this film reaches a 2°DIN higher film speed in tungsten light, due to a higher sensitivity to red light.



You can say it is normal that the curve bellies up, since all tested developers produce this - some more, some less. In tungsten light a flattening of the curve within the highlights is more apparent than in daylight. The reason for this eye catching S-shape may well be the initial designation of this film. For our purposes this is only a problem if either the foot is immensely sagging or the shoulder is too flat.

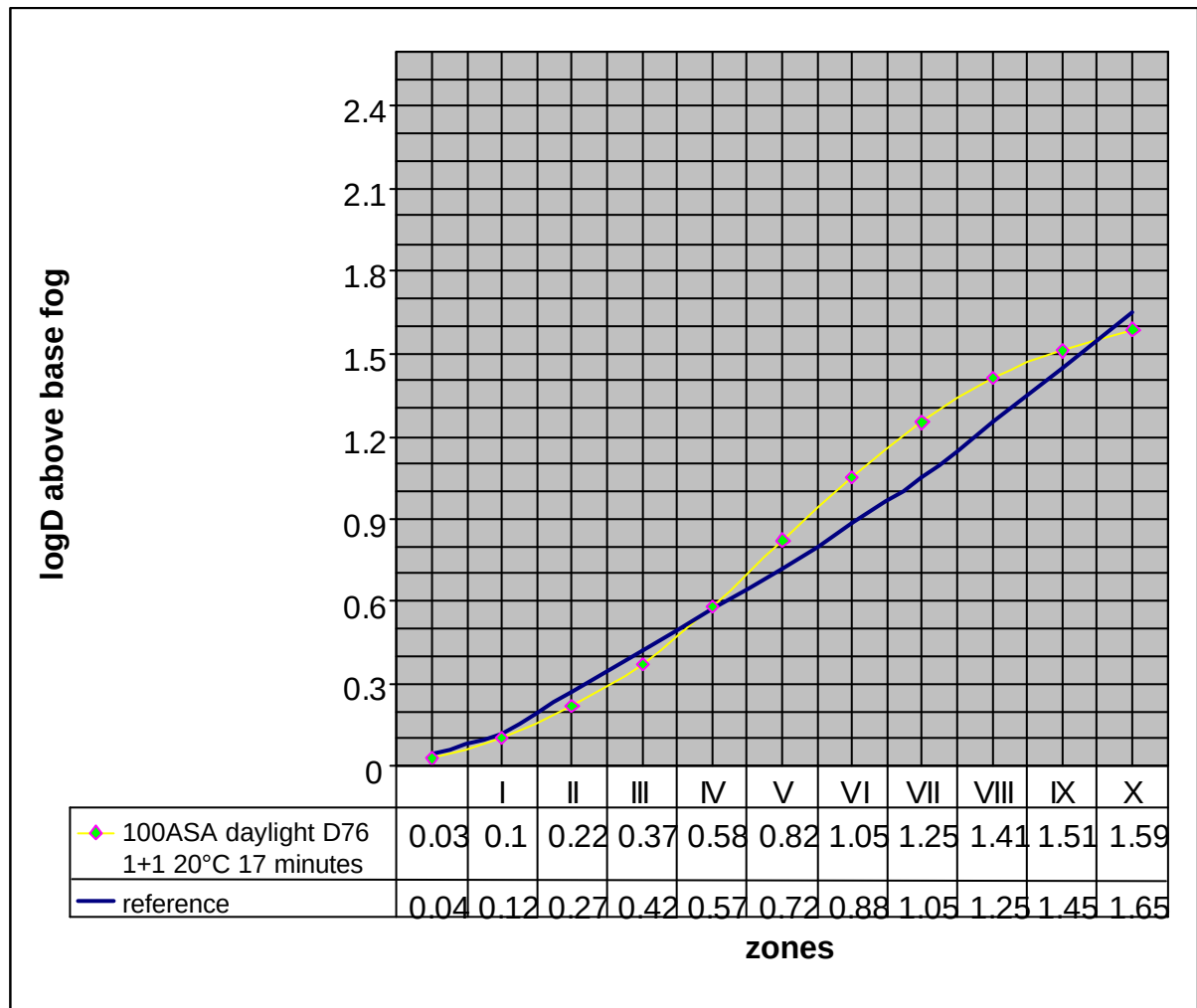


Tungsten light Finol 250 ASA – scan of a print 18.5x26cm
 Paper MGW in SE6 Blue

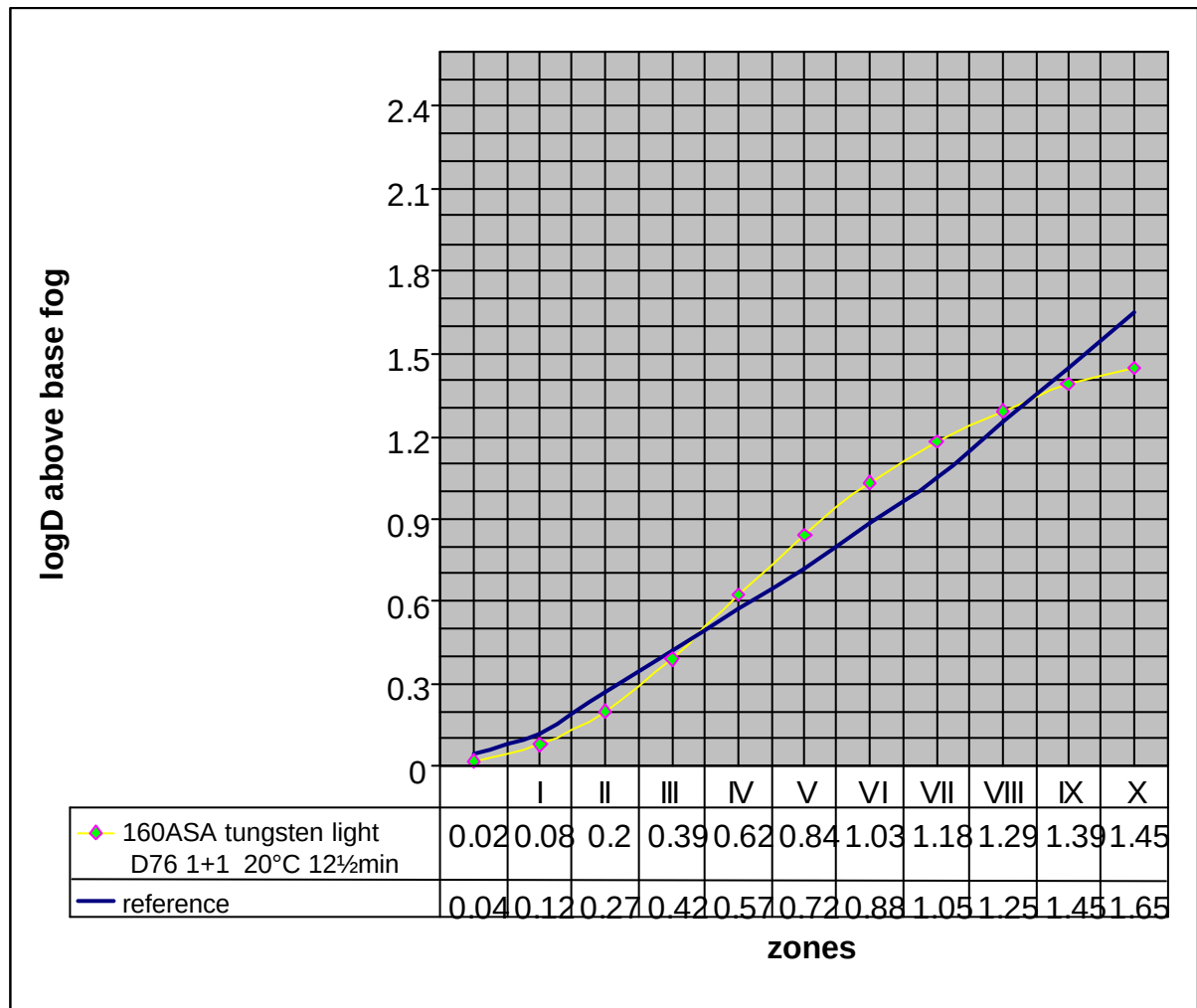


Detail of the print – compares to enlarging the complete negative to 64x90cm.

Everything needs to stand the test against the standard. The universally accepted standard developer is D76/ID11. With it you see a similar curve.

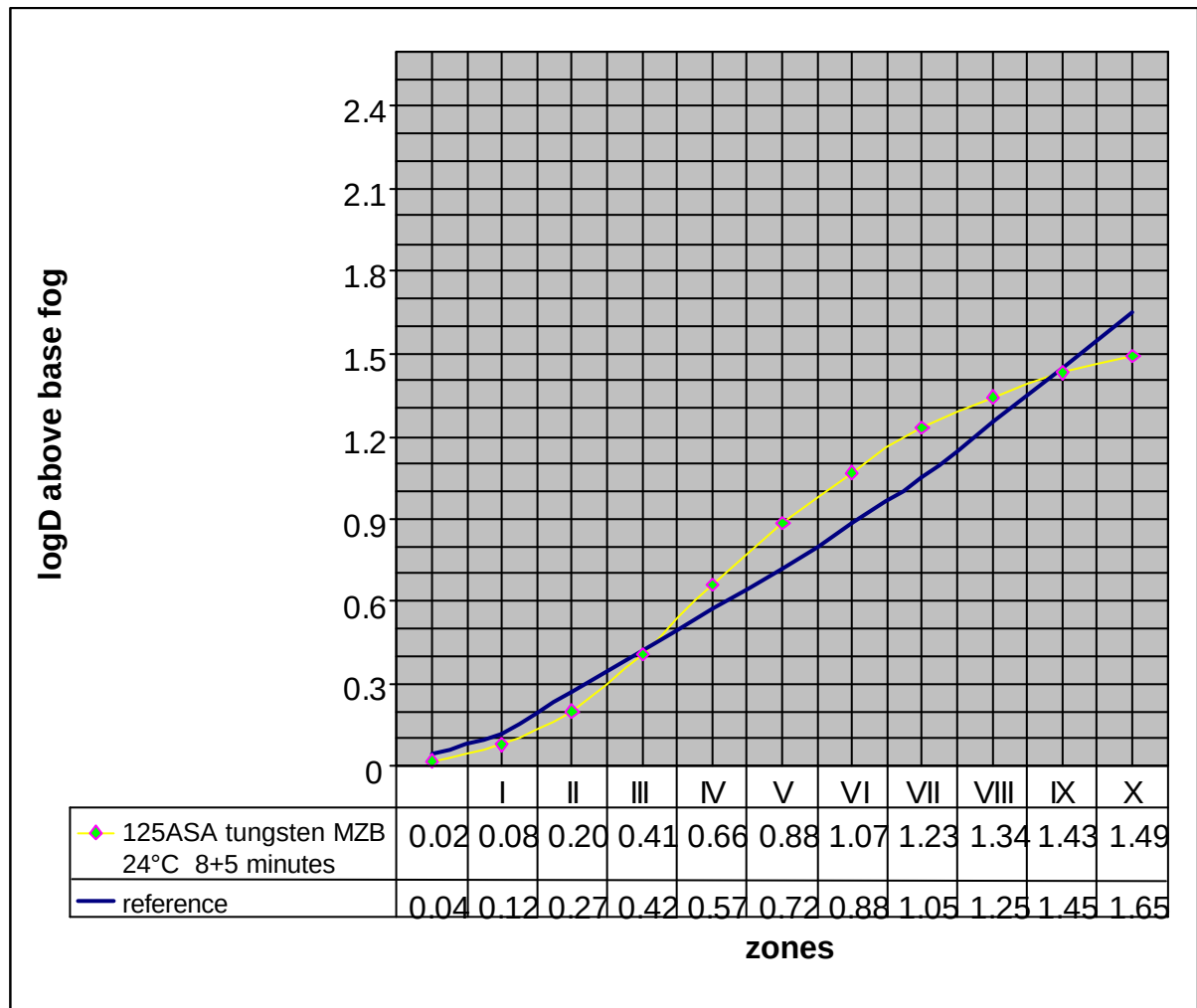


Amazingly, with D76/ID11 you only get 100 ASA in daylight.



In tungsten light with a shorter development time, you get approximately 2°DIN more film speed. If you want to elevate the complete curve, you can develop up to 14 minutes. If you only want to boost the highlight densities, more agitation is the better choice.

Compensating developers are unsuitable for a film that already shows a pronounced S-curve. I want to illustrate this with the MZB-curve in normal agitation.

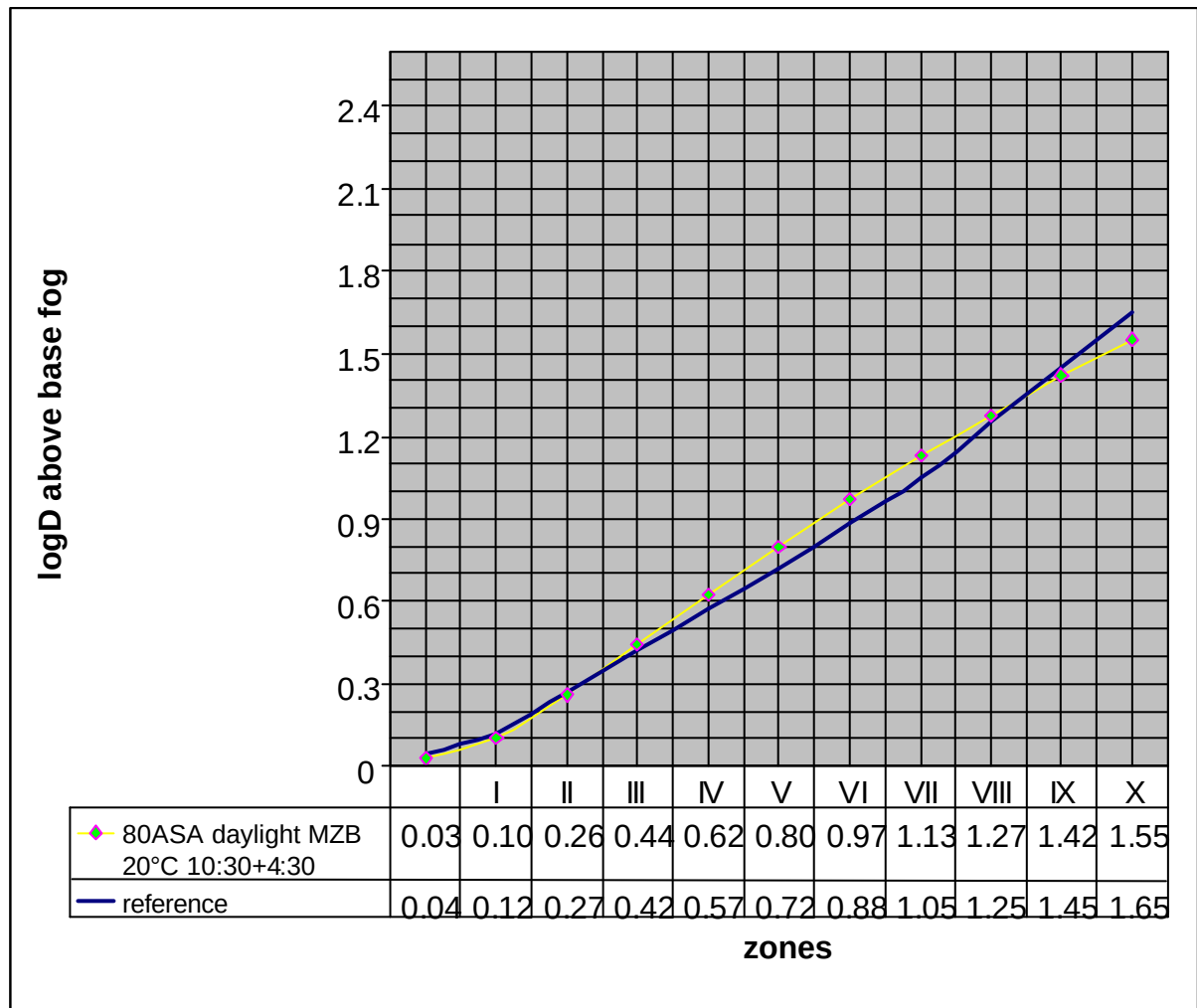


We do not reach the selected film speed and the highlight densities drop away, as anticipated.

Exposing with 100 ASA elevates the shadow densities. If you develop for a shorter time and with more agitation in the B-solution, the curve converges to the ideal line.

Used in a way other than intended:

If you use this two bath **compensating developer** the other way round, it beats the others.



Changing temperature, dilution and agitation.

If you expose the film in daylight with 80 ASA, you can straighten the curve by agitating the tank in cycles not normally intended for MZB. In the first bath reduce agitation from 4 inversions every 30 seconds to 2 inversions every 60 seconds. Use the second bath undiluted with an agitation of 4 inversions every 15 seconds, instead of the usual 4 inversions every minute cycle in a dilution of 1+1.

It seems unlikely that we want to use this altered method on a regular basis.

However, I hope the cohesions have become clear, because they are the same for every developer, separated or not.

I want to seize the opportunity to introduce a new developer, which appears to be very suitable for this film, if fine grain and highest sharpness are desired.

The developer comes in two separate solutions, to guarantee a maximum shelf life even after opening.

In tungsten light I recommend exposing the film with 100 ASA and in daylight with 64 ASA.



Tungsten light 100 ASA – scan of a print sized 18.5x25cm
Paper Vintage 111 in SE4 Neutral



Detail of a print 64x90cm

Evaluation

In combination with my own developers and with the film speed set between 50 and 250 ASA, you get outstanding results with this film. Top results in terms of sharpness and grain. As the resolution was not measured, I cannot assess whether the given data is reached. In practice an inspection with the eye is good enough for me. The separation of the tone values depends on the characteristics of the curve, which always looks a bit different for films of that category.

Push development

Don't expect too much of this. There may be developers that allow film speeds of up to 400 ASA, but the curve will come out with a huge belly. Additionally, some tests resulted in excessive grain size, although the grain itself appeared sharp.



When developing in a traditional high speed obtaining developer this 24x30cm enlargement already produced graininess that I found disturbing. But this is a question of personal taste.

IR capability

This film is in fact IR capable. Using the very same film speed as above and measured through the filter (715), the negative was overexposed for around two stops. For the print below I used the least dense negative out of my test series. I still have to determine the exact film speed for IR, but this first test is already an indicator that Superpan has a higher film speed in infrared light than Rollei IR 820/400.



Fixing times

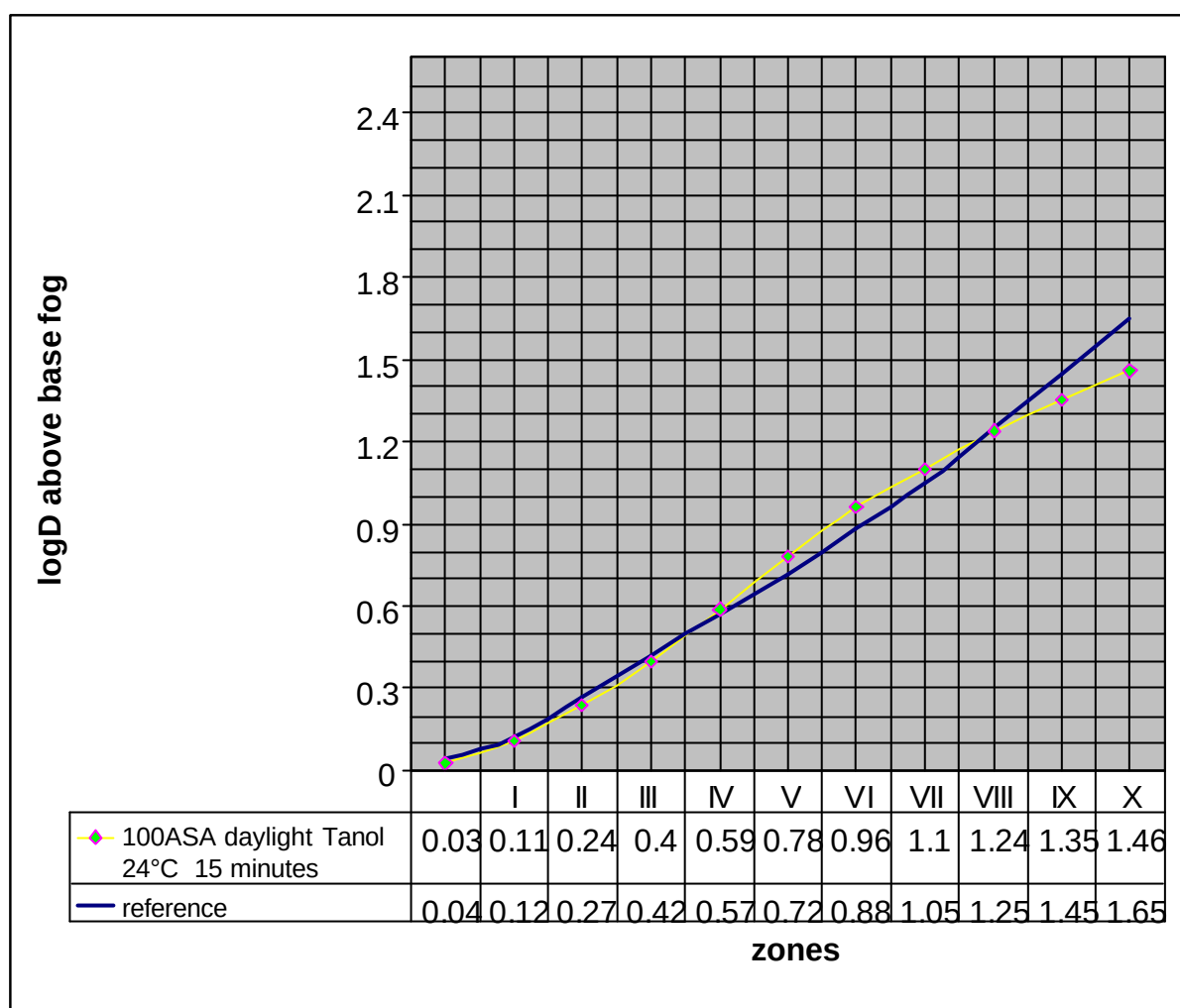
Fixing times are relatively short. In my fixer diluted to 1+5, 2½ minutes is already sufficient.

Carrier

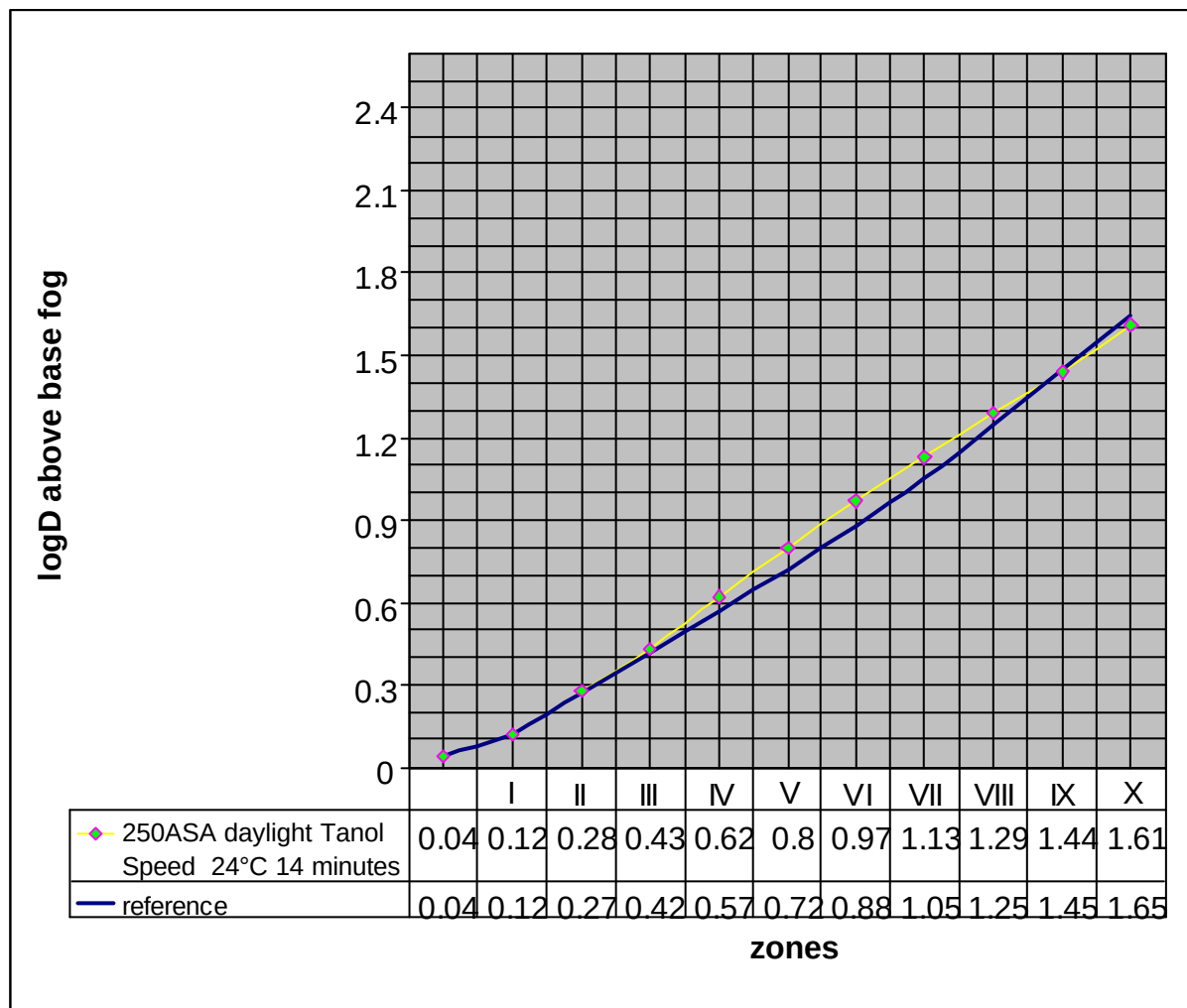
The carrier of the film is clear. With 0.07 to 0.16 (depending on the developer) the density of the fog is extremely low. When dried the film is flat – no bulging and no tension.

Development data and corresponding curves

		ISO daylight	ISO tungsten	°C	time	inversions per second
Finol	1+1+100	160/23°		24	11:30	60 – 2x30
			250/25°	24	12:30	60 – 2x20
Tanol	1+1+100	100/20°		24	15:00	60 – 2x30
			160/23°	24	14:00	60 – 2x30
Tanol Speed	1+1+100	250/25°		24	14:00	60 – 2x15
			400/27°	24	15:00	60 – 2x15
masc	1+1+40	64/19°		20	13:00	30 – 2x15
			100/21	20	11:30	30 – 2x15
MZB		80/20°		24	6:30	30 - 4x30
normal processing					3:30	15 – 2x30



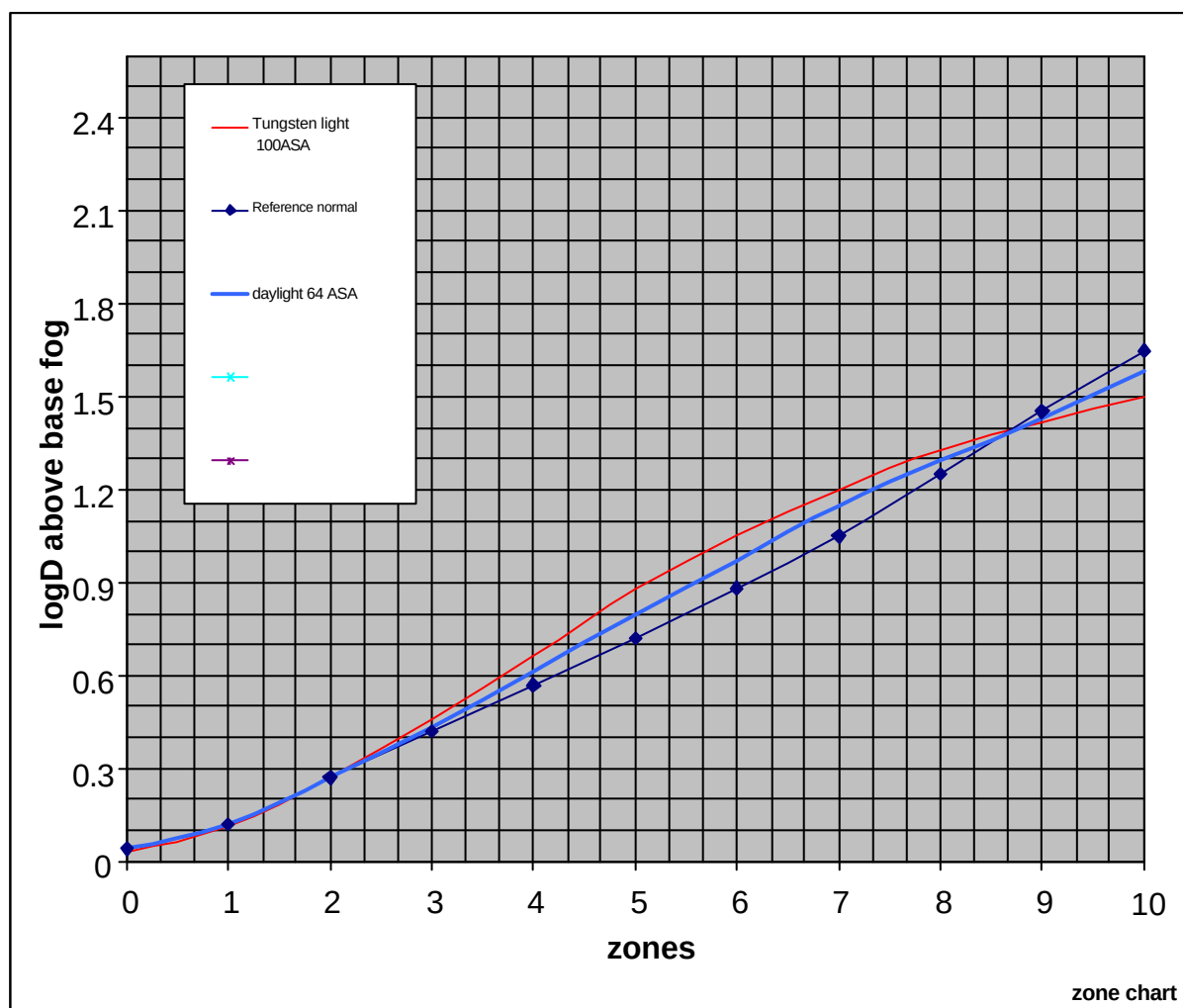
This is the curve of only the silver - this reading was done without the stain.
In tungsten light we can assume that the actual film speed is 2°DIN higher.



The curve of only the silver

The density of the base fog is 0.16 logD. The stain is in a strong yellow green.

Films that have been developed in Tanol Speed cannot be printed on graded paper, due to the strong (blue absorbing) stain.



New developer – Prototyp masc
 Superpan tungsten light @100 ASA
 6+6+240ml 20°C 11½ minutes
 Superpan daylight @64 ASA
 6+6+240ml 20°C 13 minutes

Agitation: permanently during the first minute, then 2 inversions every 15 seconds.